

STRL pitch deck

PITCH — STRL — VERDICT

PROPOSED — PENDING ADJUDICATION — no position today at \$504.80; a ⅓-size starter is proposed only on a pullback into \$464 or lower, because the only fair-value math in the record puts the stock *above* the top of its own value band.

What we believe

Sterling is a real, cash-generating heavy-civil and site-work contractor that is growing fast and just raised its full-year outlook. On the company's own numbers, second-quarter revenue was \$1.17 billion, up 90% year over year, of which acquisitions contributed \$250.8 million — so the underlying business grew about 49% on its own ([company release](#)). Full-year guidance is revenue of \$4.00–4.15 billion, GAAP diluted EPS of \$17.25–17.85, and adjusted EBITDA of \$891–916 million ([Q2 8-K, 2026-08-03](#)).

So our belief is narrow and unglamorous: **the business is not damaged, but it is not cheap either**. The stock is down about half from its 52-week high, and that fact alone tempted the first draft of this pitch into calling it a “50% discount.” That framing is dead. From the low of \$281.58 the stock has already risen 79%. At \$504.80 it trades at 28.3–29.3x this year's GAAP guided earnings, 24.9–25.6x adjusted earnings, and about 17.4x the midpoint of adjusted EBITDA. Those are full prices for a contractor.

What we would actually be buying, if we bought, is **durability**: that the order book (combined backlog \$5.62 billion, signed \$4.33 billion, signed up 116% year over year) keeps converting into work in 2027 and beyond at decent margins. That is a next-year question, not a this-quarter question, and the answer arrives in pieces at the next earnings print.

What the market believes

The market believes two things at once, and they are not contradictory.

First, the sell side is bullish and loud: eight analysts, a “Strong Buy” consensus, and an average price target of \$876. Buying at \$505 is not fighting the street — it is **agreeing** with the street at a 42% discount to its own target. That is an uncomfortable place to claim edge.

Second, the tape is skeptical of the *mix*. The company beat and raised on August 3–4 and the shares fell anyway. Five weeks have passed with every number public. The market's working theory appears to be that the growth being bolted on — the acquired units, guided at mid-teens EBITDA margins on roughly \$180–200 million of revenue — dilutes the company's ~21–22% blended margin, so revenue growth overstates earnings growth. That is the priced narrative.

Why we might have edge

Honest answer: **thin, and mostly in the specifics, not the story.**

1. **The guidance basis is genuinely unresolved in public.** The prior outlook (May 4) was revenue \$3.70–3.80 billion and EBITDA \$801–831 million ([May 8-K exhibit](#)). The new outlook shows two different EBITDA figures circulating — roughly \$829–854 million on one label and \$891–916 million on another. Which label the May figure matches decides whether the raise was **dilutive (+\$25.5M EBITDA on +\$325M revenue = 7.8% incremental margin)** or **accretive (+\$87.5M = 26.9% incremental, above the 21.8% base)**. Same company, same quarter, opposite conclusions. Nobody in our record actually opened the exhibit and settled it. That is a one-hour job with a real payoff.
2. **Labor hiring is still rising at the newly acquired units.** Record job-req counts step up 3–5x into August–September 2026 (Plateau roughly 2/quarter → 8 then 10; Stone Ridge 1–4/month → 9, 13, 14). If real, a company does not staff up into a slowdown. It is contaminated evidence (see below), but it points the opposite way from the de-rating story.
3. **The valuation kill priced the wrong year.** The 15–17x multiple applied to this year’s EBITDA embeds effectively no growth, on a signed book up 116%. If 2027 durability is even half-proven, the multiple is the wrong anchor.

Why it might be priced in

- **28–29x guided GAAP earnings is on every screen.** There is no secret in the P/E. Our “cheap” call requires the multiple to be wrong, not the data to be unknown.
- **Margin mix was call material.** Management discussed the acquired units’ mid-teens margins openly. The market did the arithmetic before we did.
- **Backlog composition is public too.** Signed backlog covers about 1.06x this year’s revenue; the unsigned \$1.28 billion is 96.9% sitting at the two newest units. Anyone can see it.
- **Insider selling is public.** A Form 144 on 2026-06-25, a run of Form 4s from May through August, and large CEO sales in March 2026 are all on file.
- **Our own scenario math says it is roughly fair.** Expected value on our table is \$482 against a \$505 tape — a *negative* 4.5% edge at today’s price. That is the cleanest statement of “priced in” we can make.

What could go wrong

Failure narrative 1 — the dilution is real and the label resolves against us (tripwire exists). The Q3 exhibit states the outlook on one basis and the raise turns out to be 7.8% incremental margin, not 26.9%. Earnings growth then lags revenue growth for two years while the acquired units are integrated, and 28x becomes 20x on unchanged earnings. *Monitorable:* the Q3 8-K exhibit, the E-Infrastructure segment margin line, and any guide language change. Price consequence roughly \$400–430.

Failure narrative 2 — the order book converts late (tripwire exists). The \$1.28 billion of unsigned backlog is concentrated at the least-seasoned units. If less than about \$400 million converts with named awards by year-end, the “durability” thesis has no evidence for two more quarters while we pay a full multiple to wait. *Monitorable*: named award announcements (8-K/PR), signed-backlog line each quarter, Austin-area permit pulls for the electrical unit’s work-in-place (our permit read timed out and was never restored).

Failure narrative 3 — NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE. Roughly 92% of the E-Infrastructure book sits inside a single capital-spending cycle driven by a small number of very large private customers whom the company does not name. A decision made in one customer’s capital committee — a pause, a re-phasing, a change of contractor, a change of data-center design that needs less earthwork — reaches us only *after* it has already reached the backlog line, one quarter later. There is no filing, no permit, no satellite pass and no hiring series that front-runs it, because the customer is private and the parcels belong to the customer, not to Sterling. **Unknown-unknown class: “private counterparty capital-allocation reversal at an undisclosed concentrated customer” — an off-tape, off-filing decision at an entity we cannot name, cannot monitor, and cannot subpoena.**

Adjacent named class: *undisclosed-customer concentration risk in percentage-of-completion contracting*. We accept that this one is un-sensored, which is itself an argument for small size rather than for a wider stop.

Reflexive / structural leg. Our own size is not the problem; the *company we would be keeping* is. Average daily volume is not in the pack — our estimate is 0.6–1.2 million shares, roughly \$300–600 million of notional a day — so even a full 3%-of-book target is a small fraction of one day’s turnover. We move nothing. The reflexive risk runs the other way:

- **Predicted flow is crowded and one-directional.** Consensus “Strong Buy” with an average target of \$876 means the marginal seller on bad news is a disappointed bull with a published target, not a valuation buyer. Air pockets under crowded longs are deeper than the fundamentals justify, and our proposed add band (\$460) sits directly in that air pocket.
- **Doctrine interaction 1 — mechanical adds into a re-rate.** Our add gates are written as “resolve the guide basis, show \$800M converted, show the net-debt bridge.” All three resolve on the *same* 8-K. If they resolve well, the stock gaps and our gates fire at a worse price than the band; if they resolve badly, none fire and we hold only a starter. The gate structure is therefore asymmetric against us in the good case — we should expect our average entry to be above the band, not at it.
- **Doctrine interaction 2 — “damage-absent” vs “divergence-not-coverage.”** The classification doctrine says the business is intact, so hold. The divergence doctrine says agreeing with a “Strong Buy” street is not edge, so pass. Both fired here and they point in opposite directions; the resolution we chose (own it small, only below fair value) is a compromise, not a proof, and a compromise sized at ⅓ can lose money in a way that neither doctrine would have flagged as a doctrine failure.
- **Structural overhang.** Insider distribution (Form 144 on 2026-06-25, six Form 4s May–August) plus 13G/A churn on 2026-07-30 and 2026-09-04 means supply is present but

unquantified — we never pulled net-holdings deltas or 10b5-1 adoption dates, so we cannot tell programmed selling from discretionary selling.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be that we paid roughly 29x guided earnings for 2027 durability that arrives a year later than the tape needs — the guide basis resolved to the dilutive label and the unsigned \$1.28 billion converted slowly — and we did it while agreeing with a crowded “Strong Buy” street that had nothing left to upgrade.

What we checked ourselves

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
Tape price and drawdown	Recomputed from pack: 504.8 / 1005.68 – 1; 504.8 / 281.575 – 1	dd52 = –0.4981; off-low = +0.7928. Matches the pack (–0.498 / 0.793).	Confirmed
OUR BENCH ERRED — red bench tape	Same arithmetic on red’s numbers	Red anchored to px 514.085 , off-low +0.8257, dd52 –0.4888. Internally consistent but it is not the pack tape ; the pack says 504.8. Red’s whole valuation gap (\$514 vs FV top \$493) was computed off a price no one else has.	Confirmed error
OUR BENCH ERRED — blue bench tape	Same	Blue used 504.88 (pack: 504.80) — trivial, but blue also earlier published 514.14 / –0.518 / a market-cap line that exists in neither pack copy. Blue correctly self-charged this.	Confirmed error
OUR BENCH ERRED — red’s fatal kill contradicted itself	Read red #1 against red #3	Red quoted adjusted EBITDA guidance of \$891–916M in one finding and used \$829–854M in the next for the identical guide. On the first figure the raise is accretive (26.9%), on the second dilutive (7.8%). A “FATAL” verdict rested on the unreconciled pair.	Confirmed error
OUR BENCH ERRED — blue overturned it too hard	Our own bridge math	The two new EBITDA figures differ by exactly \$62M , and the adjusted-vs-GAAP EPS gap is \$2.45/share ≈ \$76M after tax — consistent with acquisition intangible amortization, which shows up in the EPS bridge but <i>not</i> in an EBITDA bridge. That pattern suggests the May “\$801–831M” most likely pairs with the new \$829–854M label, i.e. red’s 7.8% may well be right and blue’s “the opposite of the claim” is an overreach. Still unproven either way.	Not confirmed — open (item 1)
Organic growth math	(1168 – 250.8) / 614.7 – 1	+49.2% . The 90% headline is basis-shifted but the basis was disclosed in the release.	Confirmed (fact); reduced as a kill)
Fair-value band	15/16/17x × \$903.5M adj-EBITDA mid ÷ 31.16M shares	\$434.9 / \$463.9 / \$492.9 . Tape \$504.80 = 17.4x , i.e. above the top of the band .	Confirmed arithmetic; multiple itself unsourced

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
Share count	\$155.8M net income ÷ \$5.00 GAAP EPS	31.16M diluted — supersedes the pack's stale 30.762M	Confirmed
Pack XBRL block usable?	Inspected	Revenue series ends 2017-09-30 ; SBC/OCF/diluted shares are Q1-only through 2025-03-31. Unusable for this pitch — both benches agree, and this is a pack defect, not a bench defect.	Confirmed unusable
P/E on guidance	504.8 ÷ (17.25, 17.85, 19.70, 20.30)	29.3x / 28.3x GAAP; 25.6x / 24.9x adjusted	Confirmed
"Market hasn't priced it"	Beat-and-raise on 8/3–8/4, shares fell; five weeks public; consensus Strong Buy, avg PT \$876	The refuting facts have been public and the tape has traded on them. Long here agrees with the street.	Confirmed — edge claim refuted
Insider distribution "into the peak"	Dates	Large CEO sales are March-dated, before the 6/4 high ; the Form 144 is 6/25. Overhang is real; "sold the peak" is not established (no 10b5-1 dates, no net-holdings delta).	Partly confirmed — sizing only
Hiring ramp as evidence	Record pre-flight	Req counts do step up 3–5x into Aug/Sep, but there is no baseline normalization for job-board recency decay and one sample row names a third-party company . Cuts both ways; cannot corroborate conversion.	Not confirmed — open (item 8)
Physical verification of work-in-place	Permit/imagery detectors	Zero independent reads survived pre-flight: Austin permits timed out (Socrata read failure), imagery needs a named customer parcel Sterling does not disclose, thermal is uninformative (an admin office, not a plant).	Confirmed coverage gap
Is a SCIENCE BRIEF in the inputs?	Scanned input pack	Brief block is empty ; STRL is a heavy-civil contractor, not a deep-tech name.	Confirmed — SCIENCE BRIEF DIGEST section correctly omitted, not a PRD violation

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

No entry today. At \$504.80 the stock is above the top of the only fair-value band in the record (\$434.9–\$492.9), and our own scenario table has an expected value of **\$482.25 — about 4.5% below the tape**. You do not pay up for a durability story you cannot yet verify.

Reopen / entry bands (all from the benches' own arithmetic):

Action	Price / condition	Size	Basis
Starter	≤ \$463.90 (16x adjusted-EBITDA midpoint ÷ 31.16M shares)	0.5% of book (½ of a 3.0% target)	Blue's fair-value midpoint; EV at that price is +3.9%

Action	Price / condition	Size	Basis
Add 1	≤ \$434.90 (15x — red’s own “then the discount exists” line, ≈\$430)	+ 0.5% (to 1.0%)	Bottom of the FV band; EV +10.9%
Add 2 — gated, not price-triggered	Only after the Q3 8-K delivers all three : (i) full-year EBITDA stated on one basis, resolving \$829–854M vs \$891–916M; (ii) ≥ \$800M of the \$1.28B unsigned tranche converted with named awards; (iii) a net-debt bridge after the Stone Ridge deal	+ 1.0% (to 2.0%), paid up to \$540 if the gates clear cleanly	Expect to pay above the band in the good case — the gates all resolve on one filing
Do not add	Above \$540 under any gate outcome	—	18.6x adjusted EBITDA; the multiple, not the business, becomes the bet
Trim	Half the position if gate (i) resolves to the dilutive label and conversion is <\$400M	—	Failure narrative 1 + 2 together
Exit	Full exit on a guidance cut, or on an unexplained fall in signed backlog	—	The only two things that break “damage-absent”
Hard stop	–25% from average cost with no gate resolution	—	Un-sensored customer-concentration risk (failure narrative 3)

Catalyst dates: Q3 print **2026-11-02 — UNCONFIRMED** (yfinance-derived; a second vendor says Nov 9; prior-year comp was Nov 4). A scheduling press release historically lands ~2 weeks ahead, so watch ~**2026-10-19**. Q3 10-Q follows within days of the print. Print is ~36 trading days out from the 2026-09-11 pack stamp: **no print-decisive race, no pre-print reconstruction owed.**

ARMED SENSORS

- NONE ARMED — the deck must flag this as a gap

MISSING — implied by both courts, not yet armed: - **Price gate \$463.90** (starter band) — unarmed. - **Price gate \$434.90** (add band) — unarmed. - **Price gate \$540** (no-add ceiling) — unarmed. - **8-K / earnings-release watch** for the full-year EBITDA basis reconciliation — unarmed; this is the single highest-value sensor in the deck. - **8-K / PR watch for named awards** converting the \$1.28B unsigned tranche — unarmed. - **10-Q XBRL pull** for contract assets vs contract liabilities, and for debt after Stone Ridge — unarmed (both benches conceded no check ran). - **Form 4 / 144 watch** with net-holdings delta and 10b5-1 adoption dates — unarmed. - **Scheduling-PR watch** to

confirm or move the 2026-11-02 date — unarmed. - **Austin (and peer-jurisdiction) permit re-run** after the Socrata timeout — unarmed; the only filing-free read on work-in-place. - **Hiring re-scan with baseline normalization and identity de-duplication** — unarmed; required before the hiring series is usable by either side. - **Options chain snapshot** (chain-level midpoint IV, not the aggregate feed) — unarmed; without it the vol section below cannot be completed.

What remains unverified

1. **Which basis the full-year EBITDA guide is stated on** — \$829–854M or \$891–916M.
Decides dilutive (7.8% incremental) vs accretive (26.9%). Drainable now from the 8-K exhibit.
2. **Net debt and total capital structure after the Stone Ridge acquisition.** Cash of \$464.5M is known; debt is not. Every per-share fair value in this deck converts an enterprise multiple to equity **without** this, so the band could shift by roughly $\pm \$20\text{--}40/\text{share}$. Drainable now from the 10-Q XBRL.
3. **Conversion of the \$1.28B unsigned backlog tranche** (96.9% at the two newest units) into signed work with named customers. Time-gated to the Q3 print. Estimate: **55–75% conversion within 12 months**, industry base rate for site-work/electrical pipeline-to-signed, $p(\geq \$800\text{M converted by the Q3 print}) \approx 0.45$.
4. **Whether operating cash flow is earned or customer float.** First-half OCF of $\sim \$328\text{M}$ is $\sim 16\%$ of first-half revenue for a percentage-of-completion contractor; the contract-asset/contract-liability roll is not in our excerpt, and the filing carries variable-interest-entity and non-controlling-interest tags, so consolidated cash includes a slice we do not fully own. Drainable now from the 10-Q.
5. **FY27 consensus EPS range.** Only a price target (\$876) was retrievable; without the earnings range we cannot say whether our own view diverges or merely rhymes. Drainable now from a vendor/broker fundamentals pull.
6. **Crew and equipment capacity** (capacity_check → NOT_DISCLOSED). Never disclosed by the company; not drainable. Estimate from siblings: revenue per employee $\sim \$450\text{--}600\text{k}$ for listed heavy-civil peers, implying headroom of roughly **10–20%** on current backlog before subcontracting costs bite, $p \approx 0.5$.
7. **The Q3 print date.** Not drainable until the company issues a scheduling release. Estimate: **2026-11-02 to 2026-11-09**, $p(\text{Nov 2}) \approx 0.55$ based on the prior-year Nov 4 comp and the company's Monday-after-close pattern.
8. **Hiring series baseline** — whether the Aug/Sep req step-up is a real labor wave or job-board recency decay. Re-scan needed with a normalized baseline; both benches' readings are currently unusable.
9. **Seasonality comps** for the Q3 backlog dip and the Q4 weather conservatism. The seasonality tool is unavailable in this sandbox, so not drainable now. Estimate from sector base rates: Q4 revenue typically **–8% to –15%** sequentially for northern-exposed heavy civil; management's conservatism is asserted but unquantified.

10. **Options chain and implied-vol percentile.** No chain data reached either bench, so the vol read below is incomplete by construction. Drainable now from the broker chain feed.
11. **Our own tradable size versus daily volume.** Not in the pack. Estimate: **0.6–1.2M shares/day**, ~\$300–600M notional, from mid-cap industrial comps at a ~\$15B market cap; $p \approx 0.7$ that a 0.5%-of-book clip is under 5% of one day's volume.

PRIZE TABLE + VOL READ

Required here because items 3, 6, 7 and 9 are genuinely time-gated or private — they cannot be drained before the Q3 print. Anchored per anchor-and-adjust on the fair-value midpoint of **\$463.90** (16x adjusted-EBITDA midpoint), then adjusted for each gate outcome.

Scenario	What happens	Prob	Price
A — Clean sweep	Guide restated on one basis and it's the accretive read; $\geq \$800\text{M}$ converted with named awards; net cash or modest net debt	0.20	\$600 (~20x adj EBITDA, growth-adjusted)
B — Partial	Basis resolves to the dilutive label but conversion $\geq \$800\text{M}$ and leverage is fine	0.30	\$510 (flat — today's price is this scenario)
C — Muddle	Basis stays ambiguous, conversion \$400–800M, Q4 weather conservatism reiterated	0.25	\$465 (back to 16x)
D — Dilution + slip	Dilutive basis confirmed and conversion $< \$400\text{M}$	0.18	\$400 (~13.8x)
E — Cycle tail	The un-sensored risk fires: a concentrated private customer re-phases; guide cut	0.07	\$300 (~10x)

EV = $0.20(600) + 0.30(510) + 0.25(465) + 0.18(400) + 0.07(300) = \482.25 . Against the tape of \$504.80 that is **-4.5%** — a negative edge at today's price. At the \$463.90 starter band it is **+3.9%**; at the \$434.90 add band, **+10.9%**. This is the arithmetic that produces the no-entry-today verdict; the bands are not preferences, they are where EV turns positive.

Dispersion: $\sigma_{\text{table}} = \$81.40 = 16.1\%$ of spot over ~52 days to the print ($T = 0.1425$ yr). Annualized equivalent = $0.161 / \sqrt{0.1425} = 42.7\%$. Measured to a January 2027 expiry ($T = 0.345$), the same dispersion annualizes to **27.4%**.

Bimodality: the table is fork-dated on a single filing — A (20%) and D+E (25%) sit on opposite sides of one 8-K, with B and C clustered at the anchor. That is a genuine two-humped distribution, which is exactly the shape that makes options attractive **if** they are cheap.

Expression math (candidate strikes, priced off the table itself): - $C_{ours}(K = 520) = \sum p_i \cdot \max(S_i - 520, 0) = 0.20 \times 80 = \16.00 - $C_{ours}(K = 550) = 0.20 \times 50 = \10.00 - $C_{ours}(K = 600) = \$0.00$ — the table has no mass above \$600, so anything at or above the \$600 strike is worth nothing to us regardless of price - $P_{ours}(K = 460) = \$22.00$; $P_{ours}(K = 430) = \$14.50$ (relevant to a cash-secured-put route into the starter band)

Where the arithmetic stops — and the instrument output: No options chain reached either bench. We therefore have **no chain-level midpoint IV and no real quotes for the \$520/\$550 calls or the \$460/\$430 puts**, which means we cannot compute IV-vs-RV, the IV percentile, or the variance risk premium (IV – RV). We will not substitute the underlying's aggregate IV feed for chain midpoints — that is precisely the TSSI lesson, where the aggregate feed read 71 against a chain that was really 101, a 30-point error that would flip any of these decisions. The honest form of the comparison is a **threshold**: our table implies 42.7% annualized to the print. If chain-midpoint IV prints **materially below ~43%**, the \$520 call at under \$16 is cheaper than our own distribution and gated adds could be expressed in calls; if it prints above ~43%, the two-humped table is already paid for and the route is premium-selling (a \$460 cash-secured put against our own \$22 valuation) rather than buying. **Until that number exists, the arithmetic cannot output an options trade.**

Tax overlay: the only listed expiries that span both the print (Nov 2, unconfirmed — possibly Nov 9) and the gate resolutions run into **January 2027**. That puts the loss branch — 25% combined probability on D+E — **past December 31**, deferring the loss out of the current harvest year. Under the harvest-year rule that excludes the call route unless the edge numerically dominates, and it does not: EV at spot is **negative 4.5%**, so there is no dominating edge to override the deferral. A November-expiry call would keep the loss in-year but expires on or before the print date itself under the unconfirmed-date risk — buying an instrument that can expire before its own catalyst.

INSTRUMENT OUTPUT: STOCK ONLY, and none today. Buy common at \$463.90 and below, per the entry bands. **No calls** (no chain-level IV to price against, negative EV at spot, and the only workable expiry defers the loss branch past December 31). **No covered calls** (no position to cover). **No cash-secured puts yet** — the \$460 put is the right structure the moment we have a real bid/ask to compare against our \$22.00, and it is the first thing to re-run when the chain sensor is armed.

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false, "estimate": {"range": "Q4 revenue -8% to -15% sequential",
"basis": "northern-exposed heavy-civil sector base rate; management
conservatism asserted but unquantified", "p": 0.6}}, {"item":
"Options chain: chain-level midpoint IV, IV percentile, real quotes
for the $520/$550 calls and $460/$430 puts – without these the vol
read is incomplete", "instrument": "IBKR options chain snapshot
(chain midpoints only – never the aggregate underlying IV feed; TSSI
71-vs-101 lesson)", "drainable_now": true, "estimate": null},
{"item": "Our tradable size versus average daily volume (not in the
pack)", "instrument": "IBKR historical volume pull, 20-day and 60-
day ADV", "drainable_now": false, "estimate": {"range": "0.6-1.2M
shares/day, ~$300-600M notional", "basis": "mid-cap industrial comps
at a ~$15B market cap", "p": 0.7}}, {"item": "Identity of the >10%
customer(s) – disclosed as concentrated but unnamed; this is the
unknown-unknown class with no monitorable tripwire", "instrument":
"10-K concentration footnote walk-around plus named-award PRs;
likely permanently undrainable at customer level", "drainable_now":
false, "estimate": {"range": "1-3 customers at 10-25% of revenue
each; ~92% of E-Infrastructure backlog inside one capex cycle",
"basis": "segment disclosure plus data-center/hyperscaler site-work
comps", "p": 0.6}}]

```

Bench-error summary, stated plainly: the red bench anchored its entire valuation gap to a price (\$514.085) that is not in the delivered pack (\$504.80), and staked its “FATAL” finding on two unreconciled EBITDA figures for one guide. The blue bench published off-pack figures of its own, then overturned red’s dilution kill more confidently than the evidence supports — our own bridge arithmetic (\$62M EBITDA gap vs a \$76M after-tax EPS add-back, consistent with intangible amortization) suggests red’s dilutive read may in fact be the right one. Neither bench opened the exhibit that settles it. **That unopened exhibit is the cheapest work in this file, and it is item 1 in the drain queue.**

